does not necessarily always lead to mutual recognition and, further, that argumentation is not always "progressive". Even if there is open debate, Freeden suggests "a concept may be impoverished during competition over its interpretation" (1996, p. 60). For example, differences in the meanings given to the word "democracy" can feasibly remain largely invisible in social interactions between activists and donor representatives in aid programmes. Debate over the issue of communal violence may also result in frustration, and little or no refinement of concepts. Thus, while Gallie's idea of essential contestability can help to explain divergence in the ways concepts are employed, along with Freeden (1996), I argue that the nature of contestation is not always "progressive".

It should be noted that the focus on communal violence in this research was, in some ways, accidental. The initial aim was to explore narratives of democratization from within the Burmese democracy movement and to compare these with prominent narratives in the international donor community. My field research, through 2013 and 2014, involved interviews with over fifty activists, opposition leaders, and donor representatives, review of donor program and strategy documents, and participation in a number of donor and political party meetings. Thus there was no initial intent to highlight the growing issue of violence in Myanmar. However, in the course of the research it became clear that, when asked about their perspectives on democratization, many participants sought to draw on the example of reactions to communal violence. Thus, in interviews, clear connections were made between assumptions about the ideal direction of the country's democratization and how the issue of communal violence should be addressed.

Data in the form of interview transcripts, field notes, and strategy and project documents was analysed according to its presentation of the primary obstacles to democratization in Myanmar and the vision of democracy. While there was some diversity in the examples given of problems and visions, responses clustered into broad and contrasting narratives about democratization. The next section outlines the various different ways international aid workers, activists, and opposition leaders narrated democratization and how these narratives linked to different reactions to communal violence.